

“We were being slowly killed by our own people”

Associate Editor SANDEEP UNNITHAN met survivors of the CRPF's A and G company at a hospital in Raipur to piece together India's bloodiest counter-insurgency debacle

Dawn had just begun breaking over the cool dry jungle of Dantewada when the column of 81 CRPF men along with one local head constable was walking in a single file over a hillock and towards a one hectare fallow field, lined with bunds and trees. The troopers were wearing camouflage fatigues and, strangely, white sneakers bought in Raipur because the regular CRPF issue boots were unfit for long marches. The men had established a base camp three km away from Chintalnar village and had begun 'area domination' patrols in the Mukrana forest. They had two night halts where they cooked a *dal* and rice *khichdi* for themselves.

It was their second day in the Maoist stronghold but the enemy was elusive. The villagers that they came across didn't tell them anything useful. It didn't matter even if they did. The troopers did not understand the Gondi dialect spoken by the tribals; they left that to their local liaison, Head Constable Sushil Kumar Deepak. Ramesh Kumar Singh, part of the column's Quick Reaction Team (QRT) comprising of 12 men, cradled his INSAS rifle and pulled out his mobile phone. There was no signal so he looked at the watch. It was 5.50 a.m. They had been marching for nearly three hours. For some reason the QRT, supposed to be at the head of the column acting as scouts, had fallen behind. "I'm going to the front to get our orders," Assistant Commandant B.L. Meena said and walked ahead to the head of the column where the leader, Deputy Commandant Satyaw

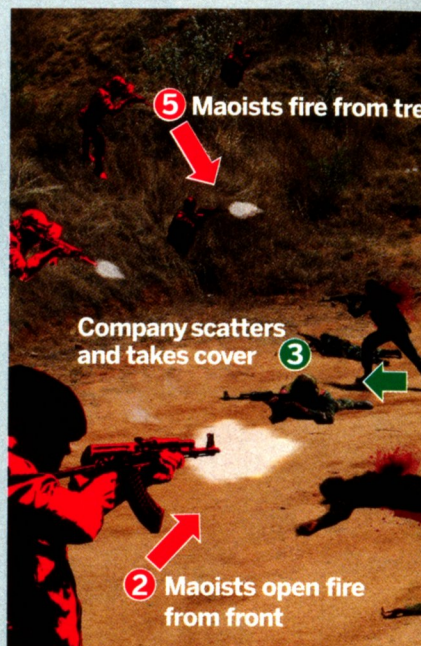
Singh, was. Meena had gone just 20 metres when the first *pft pft pft* bursts of fire came directly from the front. "Take positions, take positions," Satyaw Singh's voice rang out. The company broke up and split into small groups and fanned out to left and right, rifles pointing towards

ALIVE TO TELL THE TALE



"I knew death was certain, so I decided to kill as many of them as I could before dying."

ARVIND KUMAR



"They were firing at us with everything, AK-47s, INSAS rifles, light machine guns and SLRs."

RAMESH KUMAR SINGH

their assailants.

"It's a hit-and-run. They will go away. It happened like this in Kashmir," thought Biplab Malakar, a lanky first division fast bowler from Barrackpore in West Bengal, as he took position behind a 2-ft high bund around the field. Five years ago, militants in Jammu and Kashmir had shot and killed his friend, another constable, Pradeep Sikdar. It occurred to Biplab that the Naxals were using INSAS rifles—the very rifles the CRPF troopers were using to desperately defend themselves—to shoot at him. Biplab had a deeper as-

sociation—he used to make these weapons during a two-month long summer job at the Rifle Factory in Ishapore a decade ago.

Soon the fire began from the flanks, and seemingly from above. The black uniform-clad Maoists were firing from behind the darkened silhouettes of the trees. Bullets rang over their heads with a crack as they broke the sound barrier. Biplab was huddled near the bund with a fellow policemen H.K. Malik when a grenade flew in and exploded, blowing Malik's leg away. Five bullets hit Biplab on the back and blood